

Instead, Pegula reignited her game and stunned the fans by grabbing the next five games.

Suddenly, the momentum shifted again. A trademark forehand down-the-line winner gave Sabalenka another service break to tie it up at 5-all. She put the American on her back foot with more rocket forehands to break again and wrap up the 7-5, 7-5 final.

When Pegula's forehand sailed deep on championship point, Sabalenka went down on her back, with her hands covering her face. She then went to her player's box to hug her team — coach Anton Dubrov, fitness coach Jason Stacey, her boyfriend Georgios, and hitting partner Andrei Vasilevski. In the post-match interview, she praised them. "Without them, I wouldn't exist... I love you."

"I'm speechless. So many times, I was so close, and it's always been a dream of mine," said Sabalenka, recalling her past US Open frustrations. "In the second set, I was praying. I remember those tough losses; never give up on your dream. I am super proud of myself."

The new 'Queen of Hard Courts' racked up a near-perfect 30-6 record on the surface this year.

She joined Steffi Graf, Monica Seles, Martina Hingis, and Angelique Kerber as the only women to capture the Australian and US Opens in the same year.

Sabalenka proved she's no longer an aimless groundstroke slugger, displaying more versatility than ever.

More weapons in Sabalenka's arsenal will undoubtedly boost her chances to win on Roland Garros clay and Wimbledon grass, where she's never made the final at either Slam.

At 26, it's too late to challenge Margaret Court (24 Major titles), Serena (23), or Graf (22), but unless No. 1 Swiatek matches Sabalenka's increasingly all-court prowess and Gauff and Elena Rybakina regain their peak form, Sabalenka could dominate the rest of the decade.



Shock upset: World No.1 Iga Swiatek was beaten by Pegula in the quarterfinal. REUTERS



Comeback story: Karolina Muchova nearly upset Swiatek, the Queen of Clay, in the 2023 French Open final, only to be sidelined for a total of 9 1/2 months before and after wrist surgery in February. She came back to reach the semifinal of the US Open, where she was beaten by Pegula. REUTERS